Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.
   It was hard to get transportation to the grocery store but I had to find solutions. I take a big travel bag with me when I go to specialty market. I also get water bottles so I talk to my friend to take me to get water from Walmart. We get water, vegetables, from Walmart. Also oil and sugar from Walmart. Rice and meats are from the Arabic market. So I take the big bag to help me get the groceries. I stand in the sun a long time and I go on Saturday where there are less transportations with the bus system, so it is very hard. In the winter, it was depressing. I go to Walmart walking and then I come back with the bus. I use food stamps. IRC applied for food stamps for us. They did an interview over the phone so they could apply. IRC did everything for us as refugees, they set an appointment for us with someone who decides how much we get in food stamps. A translator called us and did an interview and that's how food stamps were applied for us.

   FQ: if you stopped getting help from IRC would you know how to apply?
   No I would have to go there and I really don't know anything about applying for food stamps.

   FQ: do you have pots and pans?
   They gave us small pots and pans. So I have to cook twice to make enough food for the family. They are super small. I went to Walmart to get pots and pans, I also went to DI. I couldn't find anything, it was all expensive. They only gave us a pot and a pan.

   FQ: do you know how to cook?
   Yes, they love biryani Iraqi. They love kobah with jareesh. Meat pastries they love as well.
   a. Explore where they buy food and groceries, if they have cooking appliances, and if they know how to cook food.
2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:

a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

There was once where the food stamps was not enough for me. I was talking to a friend about how food stamps were not enough for us. Before I knew it she was knocking on the door giving us groceries. So sometimes I don't have enough food so sometimes people around us help us. If I needed to buy with my husbands income, I would but if we stopped getting financial help with our bills and completely relied on ourselves it would cause a huge problem.

i. Explore the nature of the problem such as unemployment, low income, language barriers, and lack of knowledge about resources.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

The friend who helped me gave me her number. She helps refugees. She told me when you run out of food let me know so I can help you. But I do not ask for help from her a lot. She doesn't mind helping us but I do not like to ask. She gets us halal beef, 1 chicken, cheese, pasta, things like that. Sometimes rice. They stay for the month but she does not get these for us every month. This happened maybe once or twice. When I had more control over food situation, I started using my husbands income if necessary. He does not get a lot maybe 900 a month.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

IRC

When we first got here, they put us in houses, and we found the fridge full of food. They prepared everything for us because we were refugees. This helped us until we got the food stamps. The food stamps were a little late, so the caseworker would bring us food.

i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.

ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

They taught me how to use public transportation. They got us a bus pass for a year. I remember a girl named Yasmin came here and helped us to learn how to use the public transportation and she went with us. She told us that we had to learn. They got us a primary care doctor and Medicaid. They taught us how to get to IRC. She taught me where the Iraqi market is so she taught me how to get there. They applied for our social security, work permits, and Medicaid.

iii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Hopefully, If I start working I will be able to help myself.

FQ: let us say that after a year you graduate from IRC, and they stop providing you with help with food stamps, do you feel comfortable doing application for food stamps yourself and other necessities?

I don't know how to use the computer, I only know how to use the phone. I don't know anything about applying for food stamps. That's why I want to learn English. All the other refugees learned for free so I don't know why she told me that I had to pay.

iv. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

I told them I wished to learn English and they said to me that I needed to buy to learn. I don't have any money, I spent all my money the 10 years I spent in turkey. We came here with nothing to our name. So when she told me I had to buy, I gave up. I wish they would help me study rather than me just sitting here at home.I need to learn because my husbands income is not enough. I need to start working, my rent is high and that does not include water and electricity. I need to learn.

d. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to determine when food became a problem: Can you tell me when food became a problem?

e. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:

SNAP

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

I came as a refugee so they applied for us. I knew nothing about it. When we came here they told us that they will give food stamps. They did an interview over the phone and they just told us these are food stamps and that's what we were given.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

As food stamps, it's not enough for us. My husband would add onto it. It's good but it's not enough. I use it at Walmart and winco I get hummus and beans, and the Arab market.

FQ: does it last you the month?

No, it finishes fast. I get the things I need for half the month, the rest of the month we have to use our income.

FQ: how do you feel using food stamps?

It's a good program, I can't think of any bad feelings with it.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

2 chickens, cut up beef that I use for 4 or 5 meals. I get bread, tea as well. I also get ghee, sugar, salt, olive oil, tahani, rice, pasta, tomato pasta, juice, pepsi, vegetables, tomotoes, watermelon, eggs. I get all of these from food stamps.

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

80%, they give us 700-800 dollars for food stamps and my husband finishes the rest.

Repeat i-iv for other programs they have used.

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
   I found Iraqi food to make at home. I make a lot of food from my culture here. Yesterday I made beans and rice, today I don't have to cook dinner again. They love eggs and tomato, cheese, so I only make them lunch.
   a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

I don't feel like it is important. I love to try new things. I love to learn how to cook any food.

   b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

Specialty market, but as vegetables and things like that I find at winco and there is this Mexican grocery store that I go to sometimes but it is very far away. My friend takes me there. (Rancho) but it is very far so we can not go anymore since my friend moved out of state. Rancho even has an Arabic section with cheeses and things like that.

FQ: is there anything you wanted you weren't able to find?

No honestly.

   c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?
      Yasmin used to help me find places. She used to write the places in google and she took us and we bought things. She truly helped us.
      i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?
   d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?
      No, I don't even know it.I don't have a car how can I even get there.
   e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?
      No, I told you I only know Walmart because it is close to me and sometimes I go to the Iraqi place once a month to get the things I need, I can not go there daily. Winco I take two buses to get to it so I don't go a lot.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

   They may have high incomes so they can't use it. They told us if we made more than 3,000 they would stop providing us with food stamps.

   FQ: what else keeps them from using food pantries, or churches?

   Everything else I don't know. I thought the only help you can get in the states was food stamps. So when you mentioned all these things I was surprised. I did not even know about them.

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

   I don't know. OF course when a refugee comes here they need help. But how you can ensure it I don't know. I know they check the income to see if they can access food assistance programs. That's what I know. Every 6 months food stamps sends you letters in the mail to fill out but I don't know how to do it so I go to IRC to help me. But I know that you have to fill out paperwork.

   FQ: what do you wish you had access to when you are in need of food?

   I wish to work.

   FQ: what do you wish IRC would do to help you?

   I wish they would help me go study. Or why they told me I had to pay when other people from our community got to study for free. IRC they didn't take me to teach me or show me anything. They just gave me the food stamps and Medicaid and told me to go on my way.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

They go and see if they need it or not. They see their income or how many kids they have in their families. Help is good, so anyone who needs it should get help.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

I wish to find someone to help me because I am not going to making a lot of money when I start working. I wish for cards or cash to use for markets that I use, and tell them that I need help.